

moved from me as a shepherd's tent: I have cut off, like a weaver, my life; with pining sickness will he snatch me away:^a from day until night wilt thou make an end of me.

13 I waited (with patience) till morning, (whether)^b as a lion, so would he break all my bones: from day until night wilt thou make an end of me.

14 Like a swallow or a crane, so did I chirp; I did moan like a dove; my eyes were lifted up on high: O Lord, I am oppressed; grant me ease.

15 What shall I speak? he hath promised it unto me, and he hath also accomplished it; I will make pilgrimages (to God's house) all my years because of the bitterness of my soul.

16 O Lord, by these (things men) will live, and in all these (things) is the life of my spirit: so wilt thou give me health, and cause me to live.

17 Behold, for peace I had great bitterness; but thou hast, in loving my soul, delivered it from the pit of corruption; for thou hast cast behind thy back all my sins.

18 For the nether world will not thank thee, death will not praise thee: they that go down into the pit will not hope for thy truth.

19 The living, the living alone shall thank thee, like me this day: the father to the children shall make known thy truth.

20 The LORD is there to help me; therefore will we play my hymns all the days of our life in the house of the LORD.

21 And Isaiah had said, Let them take a lump of figs, and lay it for a plaster upon the inflammation, and he shall recover.

22 And Hezekiah had said, What is the sign that I shall go up to the house of the LORD?

CHAPTER XXXIX.

1 At that time sent Merodach-baladan, the son of Baladan, the king of Babylon, letters and a present to Hezekiah; for he had heard that he had been sick, and was become strong again.

2 And Hezekiah was rejoiced on their ac-

count, and showed them his treasure-house, the silver, and the gold, and the spices, and the precious oil, and the whole of his armour-house, and all that was found in his treasures: there was nothing that Hezekiah showed them not, in his house, and in all his dominion.

3 Then came Isaiah the prophet unto king Hezekiah, and said unto him, What did these men say? and whence did they come unto thee? And Hezekiah said, From a far-off country are they come unto me, from Babylon.

4 And he said, What did they see in thy house? And Hezekiah said, All that is in my house have they seen: there is nothing that I did not show them in my treasures.

5 And Isaiah said to Hezekiah, Hear the word of the LORD of hosts,

6 Behold, days are coming when all that is in thy house, and that which thy fathers have laid up in store until this day, shall be carried to Babylon: nothing shall be left, saith the LORD.

7 And of thy sons that will issue from thee, whom thou wilt beget, shall they take; and they shall be court-servants in the palace of the king of Babylon.

8 Then said Hezekiah to Isaiah, Good is the word of the LORD which thou hast spoken. He said moreover, For there shall be peace and stability in my days.

CHAPTER XL.

1 ¶ Comfort ye, comfort ye my people, saith your God.

2 Speak ye (comfort) to the heart of Jerusalem, and call out unto her, that her^c time of sorrow is accomplished, that her iniquity is atoned for; for she hath received from the hand of the LORD double for all her sins.

3 ¶ A voice calleth out, In the wilderness make ye clear the way of the LORD, make straight in the desert a highway for our God.

4 Every valley shall be raised, and every mountain and hill shall be made low; and the crooked shall be made a straight path, and the rough places a plain:

^a Sachs, elegantly but freely, "My life is cut off unto me, as though the weaver were to tear it off from the thread (of the web)." Life is a web, the days the single threads, which are severed by the hand of death.

^b Rashi, "I made myself strong like a lion, hoping for the morning; yet the more would he break," &c.

^c Philipsson, "its servitude." Heinemann, "her warfare." Sachs, "her time of servitude."

5 And the glory of the LORD shall be revealed; and all flesh shall see it together; for the mouth of the LORD hath spoken it.

6 ¶ A voice saith, Proclaim; and he saith, What shall I proclaim? All flesh is grass, and all its goodness is as the flower of the field:

7 The grass withereth, the flower fadeth; because the breath of the LORD hath blown upon it; surely the people is grass.

8 The grass withereth, the flower fadeth; but the word of our God will stand firm for ever.

9 ¶ Upon a high mountain get thee up, thou that bringest good tidings to Zion; lift up with strength thy voice, thou who bringest good tidings to Jerusalem; lift it up, be not afraid; say unto the cities of Judah, Behold, (here is) your God!

10 Behold, the Lord Eternal will come with might,^a and his arm ruleth for him: behold, his reward is with him, and his recompense^b before him.

11 Like a shepherd will he feed his flock: with his arm will he gather the lambs, and in his bosom will he carry them, will he lead gently those that suckle their young.

12 ¶ Who hath measured in the hollow of his hand^c the waters, and meted out the heavens with the span, and comprised in a measure^d the dust of the earth, and weighed in the scale-beam the mountains, and the hills in balances?

13 Who hath meted out^e the Spirit of the LORD? and (who was) his counsellor that he could have given him information?

14 With whom took he counsel, that he gave him understanding, and taught him the path of justice, and taught him knowledge, and caused him to know the way of understanding?

15 Behold, nations are as a drop out of a bucket, and as the small dust of the balance

are they accounted: behold, isles are like the flying dust.^f

16 And Lebanon is not sufficient for burning, and its beasts do not suffice for burnt-offering.

17 ¶ All the nations are as naught before him; less than nothing, and vanity^g are they accounted to him.

18 To whom then will ye liken God? or what likeness will ye compare unto him?

19 The graven image—this the artificer hath cast, and the goldsmith hath overspread it with gold, and fabricated (on it) silver chains.

20 He that is skilled in the choice^h chooseth a wood that will not rot; he seeketh unto himself a skilful workman to prepare a graven image, that shall not be moved.

21 Know ye not? hear ye not? hath it not been told you from the beginning?ⁱ have ye not paid attention to the foundations of the earth?

22 (It is he) that dwelleth above the circle of the earth, while its inhabitants are as grasshoppers; that stretched out the heavens as a curtain, and spreadeth them out as a tent to dwell in;

23 That bringeth princes to naught; rendering the judges of the earth as vanity.

24 Yea, they were not yet planted; yea, they were not yet sown; yea, their stem had not yet taken root in the earth: when he but breathed upon them, and they withered, and the storm-wind carrieth them away as stubble.

25 To whom then will ye liken me, that I should be equal to? saith the Holy One.

26 Lift up your eyes on high, and see who hath created these? he that bringeth out their host by number; that calleth them all by name; from him, who is great in might, and strong in power, not one escapeth.^j

27 ¶ Why wilt say thou, O Jacob, and

^a Heinemann, "as the mighty one."

^b Rashi. Jonathan, "behold, the reward of those who have done his word is with him; for all their deeds are known before him."

^c Rashi, "with his steps."

^d שיש, literally, "a third;" hence Rashi, "a third desert, a third habitable land, a third seas and rivers."

^e Rashi, after the Massorah, "Who has meted out the spirit? the Lord."

^f Jonathan. Redak, "behold, isles he lifteth up like fine dust."

^g Sachs and others, "nonentities;" properly, "the formless, chaotic state;" but it is impossible to find a simple English word nearer than "vanity."

^h Rashi, and it is then a continuation of the description of how idols are made. Others, "who is poorer in his gifts;" i. e. who cannot have an idol cast, but one carved of wood.

ⁱ Lit. "is missed;" it means that, numerous as are the stars, they all are always there to do God's bidding. The prophet contrasts the idols with God; those are the works of human hands, while He is the maker of all.



THE DECISION OF SOLOMON